

1840–1900

FORMAL WEAR FOR MEN

Gentlemen's formal dress became more sombre in shape and tone in the mid-19th century. The three-piece suit emerged in the 1860s, although it was still some years off becoming a uniform of business respectability. Fibres for all garments were still natural, but advanced machinery made more intricate weaves and colour combinations possible. The sewing machine helped the ready-made trade, while tailors' manuals with patterns for varying styles of coat proliferated. In leisurewear there were colour combinations and contrasts to delight: embroidered accessories, an intriguing glimpse of luxurious lining fabric, or a jaunty pair of striped, checked, or plaid trousers. Smart items of daywear – top hat, cravat, and pantaloons – became reserved for formal wear, while bowler hats and ties supplanted them for day. Fall front trousers gave way to fly fronts.

WAISTCOATS 1840-70

Figured, checked, or embroidered with ribbon work, decorative wool and silk waistcoats added an accent of colour to a man's outfit. Brides-to-be might embroider them in canvas work for their grooms. While the fronts were decorative, the backs, covered by a jacket, were of plain cotton with an adjustable strap.



Figured fabric



Flower garden embroidery



Woven check

1845



Chimney-pot hat

Fine wool cape

Dress suit

Quilted cape Lambswool quilting kept a gentleman warm when going to the opera or paying an evening call. The contrasting silk lining shows off fine hand stitching. Top hats were of beaver, felt, or silk.

Top hat lends stature

Leather gloves

Sleeves echo women's full bishop sleeves

1868

Buff trousers contrast with dark coat and waistcoat

Morning coat This coat and waistcoat match, is set off by light-coloured trousers. Heavy tweeds and worsted wools, used here, were the materials for winter, replacing the stout twilled linen drill and cotton nankeen trouser fabrics of summer.

Heels add a few inches to height